

Saif.dev — Project Handoff (Built in the Dark)

2026-09-22 · @Someone

Handoff for Claude Code to implement the approved "Built in the dark" portfolio direction. Everything below is locked; deviations need to come back here first.

Decisions made

Concept, locked: "Built in the dark." A single continuous dark stage where one subject is lit at a time. The visitor is taken through scenes, not handed a system to operate. Light position and temperature shift with scroll progress; nothing else animates on its own.

Rejected direction: the earlier "Saif.dev OS" concept — sidebar navigation, status bar, workspace-dashboard layout, process cards as the primary content model. Fully superseded. Do not reintroduce a sidebar, a persistent status bar, or any panel-and-chrome layout that reads as an admin tool.

Page structure: one continuous scroll, no sidebar. A floating nav pill (name + scene links + résumé button) fades in after the hero and is the only persistent chrome.

Scene order (final):

1. Hero
2. Statement
3. PocketBalance (centerpiece, pinned interactive phone)
4. Playground (4 live demos)
5. How I Build
6. Other Work
7. Closing

PocketBalance is the centerpiece. Pinned scroll section, dual control: scroll-driven by default, swipe/tap/arrow-keys overrides scroll at any point. Four screens in this fixed order — Dashboard → Insights → Categories → Transaction review.

Playground, final 4 demos: Segmented control, Number transitions, Drag to reorder, Swipe to categorize. The fourth replaced an earlier "Theme dissolve" concept — swipe-to-categorize was chosen because it's PocketBalance's own review-screen gesture rebuilt standalone, so it doubles as proof rather than decoration, and shares its drag/spring logic with the phone (build once, use twice).

Typography pairing, locked: Bricolage Grotesque (display, headlines only, 600 weight) + Geist (body/UI, 400–600) + Geist Mono (labels, figures, mono UI). Clash Display and Cabinet Grotesk were considered as display alternates and rejected in favor of Bricolage

Grotesque.

Color, locked: signal mint `#3DD68C`, held to roughly 3% of any given screen — used only where something is "alive" (status, the phone's chart, the primary action, the swipe-to-categorize demo). One secondary cool tone, indigo/violet `#5748DC`, used only as a low-opacity counter-glow behind the PocketBalance phone.

Explicitly rejected, don't reconsider: 3D scenes, particle backgrounds, a custom cursor, scroll-hijacking/smooth-scroll libraries (Lenis etc.), typewriter text effects, stock photography, company logo walls, a preloader over 1 second, sound.

Architecture

Stack: Next.js (App Router) + TypeScript (strict). Tailwind CSS with CSS-variable tokens (never raw hex/px in components). Motion (formerly Framer Motion) as the single animation library — no GSAP alongside it. No smooth-scroll library.

Global systems (build in Phase 0, everything else depends on these):

- **Token layer** — colors, type scale, spacing, radius, and motion durations/easings as CSS variables. See Design system below.
- **Stage shell** — the persistent dark background, grain layer, and a `<SceneGlow>` component that each scene mounts to declare its own light position/color; a scroll-progress hook drives the interpolation between scenes so the light reads as continuous rather than per-section.
- **Floating nav** — fades in after the hero, contains name, scene anchor links, résumé button. The only persistent chrome; not a sidebar, not fixed at full opacity from load.

Shared gesture hook — build once, reuse twice. The drag/swipe logic (pointer tracking, rubber-band resistance at range ends, commit threshold, spring settle) is written as a single hook, e.g. `useSwipeGesture()`. Two consumers:

1. PocketBalance's transaction-review screen (inside the phone).
2. Playground's "Swipe to categorize" card.

Do not fork this into two separate implementations — the Playground card is explicitly meant to reuse the phone's code, not imitate it.

PocketBalance phone component. A small state machine: `screenIndex` (0-3), `controlMode` (`"scroll"` | `"user"`), and travel `direction`. Screens are separate components receiving an `isActive` prop; each animates its own content (counting numbers, drawing the chart, staggering the list) once on first activation, not on every re-entry. Scroll-linking uses Motion's `useScroll` / `useTransform` to map scroll progress within the pinned section to `screenIndex`; any user gesture (swipe, tap, arrow key) sets

`controlMode` to `"user"` and overrides scroll until the visitor scrolls away again. This section uses `position: sticky`, not scroll-jacking — native scroll speed is preserved throughout.

Suggested structure:

```
app/  
  page.tsx                # composes the 7 scenes in order  
components/  
  stage/                  # SceneGlow, GrainLayer, scroll-progress context  
  nav/                    # floating nav pill  
  scenes/  
    Hero/  
    Statement/  
    PocketBalance/        # the phone, its 4 screens, the pinned wrapper  
    Playground/            # 4 demo cards  
    HowIBuild/  
    OtherWork/  
    Closing/  
  shared/  
    useSwipeGesture.ts  
    DeviceFrame.tsx        # shared bezel used by Hero teaser + PocketBalance  
scene  
styles/  
  tokens.css              # design system as CSS variables
```

Content as data, not hardcoded JSX. PocketBalance screen content, Other Work rows, and How I Build's three statements live in typed data files, not inline in components — adding or editing content shouldn't require touching layout code.

Performance constraints on the architecture itself: the PocketBalance section and its screens are lazy-loaded; animate only `transform` and `opacity` anywhere in the shared motion system; target Lighthouse 90+ on mobile before considering the build done.

Design system

All values below ship as CSS variables in `styles/tokens.css`. Components reference tokens only — no raw hex, px, or ms literals in component code.

Color

Token	Value	Use
<code>--stage-void</code>	<code>#06070A</code>	Page background

Token	Value	Use
<code>--stage-deep</code>	<code>#0A0C10</code>	Device frames, deepest panels
<code>--stage-screen</code>	<code>#0D1015</code>	Phone screen background
<code>--stage-panel</code>	<code>#12151A</code>	Playground cards, inline panels
<code>--stage-raised</code>	<code>#1A1F26</code>	Hover/raised states
<code>--border-hairline</code>	<code>rgba(255,255,255,0.08-0.09)</code>	All structural dividers
<code>--text-primary</code>	<code>#F2F4F7</code>	Primary text
<code>--text-secondary</code>	<code>#A7AFBA</code>	Secondary text
<code>--text-tertiary</code>	<code>#8B94A0</code>	Captions, labels
<code>--text-mono</code>	<code>#6F7883</code>	Mono labels only, never body copy
<code>--signal</code>	<code>#3DD68C</code>	The one accent — status, primary actions, PocketBalance's chart
<code>--signal-text</code>	<code>#74E9B4</code>	Accent-colored text/links
<code>--signal-wash</code>	<code>rgba(61,214,140,0.10-0.12)</code>	Tinted backgrounds
<code>--signal-border</code>	<code>rgba(61,214,140,0.28-0.32)</code>	Borders on accent elements
<code>--on-signal</code>	<code>#04150C</code>	Text on filled-mint surfaces
<code>--cool-glow</code>	<code>#5748DC</code>	Counter-glow behind the PocketBalance phone only

Data-viz palette (PocketBalance charts only): mint `#3DD68C` · sky `#5EB1EF` · violet `#9B8AFB` · amber `#F5B83D` · rose `#E879A6` .

Ratio rule: on any given screen, roughly 88% stage/surface, 9% type, 3% signal. If a scene is using more mint than that, pull it back.

Typography

Token	Face	Size / line-height	Weight	Tracking	Use
<code>--font-display</code>	Bricolage Grotesque	up to 118px	600	−4 to −4.5%	Scene headlines only, never UI
<code>--font-body-xl</code>	Geist	38–62px / tight	600	−3 to −4%	Sub-headlines
<code>--font-body-lead</code>	Geist	22px / 34px	400	0	Lead paragraphs
<code>--font-body</code>	Geist	17px / 30px	400	0	Running copy
<code>--font-small</code>	Geist	14px / 22px	400	0	Captions
<code>--font-mono-label</code>	Geist Mono	11–12px / 16–17px	500	+16 to +18%	Eyebrows, mono labels

Three weights total across the whole site: 400, 500, 600. Hierarchy comes from size and color, never from bold. All figures (balances, percentages, dates) use `font-variant-numeric: tabular-nums`.

Motion

Token	Duration	Use
<code>--dur-instant</code>	80ms	Press, toggle
<code>--dur-fast</code>	150ms	Hover, tooltip
<code>--dur-base</code>	240ms	Screen change, menu
<code>--dur-scene</code>	420ms	Section reveal (once, on first view)
<code>--dur-cinematic</code>	700ms	Hero headline + Closing headline only — the site's two bookends

Curve	Value	Use
<code>--ease-in-motion</code>	<code>cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)</code>	Everything entering
<code>--ease-out-motion</code>	<code>cubic-bezier(0.7, 0, 0.84, 0)</code>	Everything exiting
<code>--spring-gesture</code>	stiffness 500, damping 35	Drag/swipe settle

Rules: exits run at ~70% of entrance duration. One subject moves at a time per viewport. Content is never hidden behind an animation — legible in frame one. Scene-entrance reveals fire once on first scroll into view, never on re-entry. `prefers-reduced-motion` : translations/scales collapse to opacity fades, phone tilt and scroll-pinning disable, reveals still fire once but without motion.

Spacing & radius

Reuse the 4px base spacing scale and radius scale from the earlier approved system boards (`space-1` 4px through `space-24` 96px; `radius-xs` 4px through `radius-full`). Nothing here changes those — this section only adds the stage-specific color/type/motion tokens layered on top.

Implementation order

Phase	Builds	Depends on	Unblocks
0 — Foundation	Design tokens (<code>tokens.css</code>); stage shell (background, grain, <code>SceneGlow</code>); scroll-progress hook	Nothing	Every other phase
1 — Centerpiece	PocketBalance phone: device frame, 4 screens, scroll-pin + <code>useSwipeGesture</code> state machine	Phase 0	Hero's phone teaser, Playground's swipe card
2 — Editorial scenes	Hero, Statement, How I Build, Other Work, Closing	Phase 0 (Hero also needs Phase 1's device frame for its teaser)	—
3 — Playground	Segmented control, Number transitions, Drag to reorder, Swipe to categorize	Phase 1 (<code>useSwipeGesture</code> reused directly)	—
4 — Choreography & polish	Scroll-linked light shifts across scenes, cursor light, magnetic buttons, grain tuning, reduced- motion pass, Lighthouse check	Phases 0–3	Ship

Build first, in this order: (1) tokens, (2) the PocketBalance phone. Everything else is low-risk once those two exist — the phone is both the hardest piece and the one a technical reviewer will judge most closely, so protect the time for it.

Sequencing note: don't build Playground's swipe-to-categorize card before the phone's transaction-review screen — the hook should be extracted from the first real implementation, not written twice and reconciled later.

Things not to change

These are approved. If a change here seems needed, raise it before building rather than deciding it inline.

- **No sidebar, no persistent status bar, no OS/dashboard chrome.** The floating nav pill is the only persistent navigation element.
- **No scroll-hijacking or smooth-scroll library.** Scroll speed stays native everywhere, including the pinned PocketBalance section — it uses `position: sticky`, not a library that intercepts the wheel.
- **Scene order is fixed:** Hero → Statement → PocketBalance → Playground → How I Build → Other Work → Closing.
- **PocketBalance screen order is fixed:** Dashboard → Insights → Categories → Transaction review.
- **Signal color stays rare.** Mint is not a general brand color to reach for — it marks “alive” only (status, the phone’s own chart, the primary action, the swipe-to-categorize demo). If a component is reaching for mint and isn’t one of those, it’s the wrong choice.
- **Display face (Bricolage Grotesque) is for scene headlines only** — never for UI labels, buttons, or body copy.
- **Three type weights total** (400/500/600) across the entire site. Hierarchy comes from size and color, not additional weights.
- **Content animates once, on first arrival**, not on every scroll re-entry. A returning scroll through a scene should not replay its reveal.
- **The `useSwipeGesture` hook is shared**, not forked, between the phone and the Playground card.
- **No fake/lorem data in the PocketBalance screens** — use real PocketBalance screens or real-looking data pulled from the actual app, not placeholder amounts.
- **Reduced-motion and no-JS fallbacks are required, not optional:** reduced motion collapses translations/scales to opacity and disables tilt/pinning; if JS fails, the four PocketBalance screens must still render as static stacked images with captions.
- **Lighthouse 90+ on mobile is a hard target**, checked before considering any phase done, not deferred to the end.